of groups which may be given" [**12**, p. 247]. Moreover, although Mac Lane and Eilenberg believed that category theory "offered a conceptual view of parts of mathematics", they regarded it merely as "a handy language", "a language of orientation", not as a "field for further research effort" [**35**, pp. 334–335].

Although Eilenberg and Mac Lane invented category theory, for them "it was always an applied subject, not an end in itself. Categories were defined in order to define functors, which in turn were defined in order to define natural transformations, which were defined finally in order to prove theorems that could not be proved before". They viewed categories as instruments of mainstream mathematics. The idea that categories could be used "to state theorems that could not be stated before, that they were not tools but objects of nature worthy of study in their own right", sounded alien to them, for it seemed to place category theory on the fringe, outside the mainstream (Freyd in [**6**, p. 1351]). In the hands of Alexander Grothendieck, Daniel Kan, and Eilenberg's students, however, category theory became a dynamic field in its own right, profoundly transformed algebraic geometry, topology, and representation theory, and resonated across a wide range of disciplines, from mathematical logic and theoretical computer science to linguistics and philosophy. In the work of William Lawvere, category theory came to be regarded as a foundation for all of mathematics (Heller in [**6**, p. 1349]; [**7**, p. 362]).

Category theory caused a controversy within the group of French mathematicians who worked under the pseudonym Nicolas Bourbaki with the aim of producing a multivolume rigorous treatment of all contemporary mathematics from a unified conceptual point of view. On Weil's invitation, Eilenberg joined the group in 1950 and remained an active member for 15 years. "He knew admirably how to present his point of view, and he often made us agree to it", recalled Henri Cartan, another Bourbaki member (Cartan in [**6**, p. 1345]). Mac Lane was invited to attend a private Bourbaki meeting in 1954, perhaps with the idea that he would persuade the group to adopt the category-theoretical approach. Cartier, Chevalley, Eilenberg, and Grothendieck supported Mac Lane, but André Weil took